

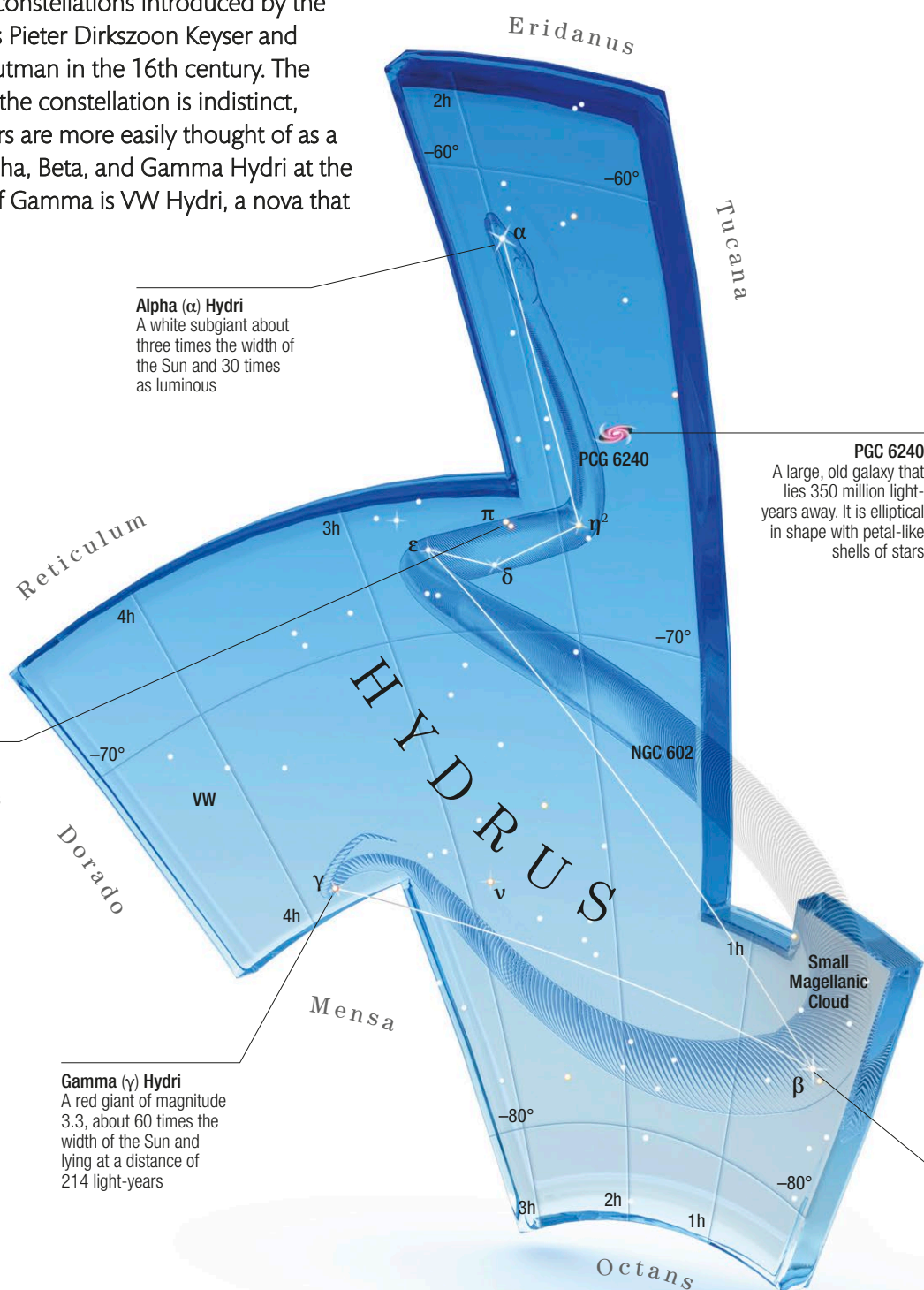
# HYDRUS

## THE LITTLE WATER SNAKE

HYDRUS FORMS A ZIGZAG IN THE SKY SOUTH OF THE BRILLIANT STAR ACHERNAR IN NEIGHBORING ERIDANUS. IT IS SOMETIMES CONFUSED WITH HYDRA, THE WATER SNAKE, BUT THE LATTER IS MUCH BIGGER AND LIES FARTHER NORTH.

Hydrus is situated between the Large Magellanic Cloud in Dorado and the Small Magellanic Cloud in Tucana, with the star Achernar to the north. It is one of the 12 constellations introduced by the Dutch navigators Pieter Dirkszoon Keyser and Frederick de Houtman in the 16th century. The snake pattern of the constellation is indistinct, and its bright stars are more easily thought of as a triangle, with Alpha, Beta, and Gamma Hydri at the corners. North of Gamma is VW Hydri, a nova that

explodes roughly once a month, and is easy to see with a small telescope. An outlying region of the Small Magellanic Cloud lies just within Hydrus.



**Alpha (α) Hydri**  
A white subgiant about three times the width of the Sun and 30 times as luminous

**Pi (π) Hydri**  
A double star that is visible as two red giants through binoculars; one is about 470 light-years away, the other is half that distance again

**Gamma (γ) Hydri**  
A red giant of magnitude 3.3, about 60 times the width of the Sun and lying at a distance of 214 light-years

**PGC 6240**  
A large, old galaxy that lies 350 million light-years away. It is elliptical in shape with petal-like shells of stars

### KEY DATA

|                               |                                |
|-------------------------------|--------------------------------|
| <b>Size ranking</b>           | 61                             |
| <b>Brightest stars</b>        | Beta (β)<br>2.8, Alpha (α) 2.8 |
| <b>Genitive</b>               | Hydri                          |
| <b>Abbreviation</b>           | Hyl                            |
| <b>Highest in sky at 10pm</b> | October–December               |
| <b>Fully visible</b>          | 8°N–90°S                       |



CHART 2

### MAIN STARS

|                                          |                  |
|------------------------------------------|------------------|
| <b>Alpha (α) Hydri</b><br>White subgiant | ↔ 72 light-years |
| <b>Beta (β) Hydri</b><br>Yellow subgiant | ↔ 24 light-years |

### DEEP-SKY OBJECTS

|                                                          |
|----------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>PGC 6240</b> (White Rose Galaxy)<br>Elliptical galaxy |
| <b>NGC 602</b><br>Cluster of young stars                 |



**△ NGC 602**  
This star cluster lies at the heart of a huge star-forming nebula known as N90. Star formation started in the center of the cluster NGC 602 then moved outward. Radiation from the brilliant, blue, newly formed stars is continuing to sculpt the inner edges of the nebula, and the youngest stars are still forming along the nebula's long ridges of dust.

**Beta (β) Hydri**  
A yellow subgiant lying only 24 light-years away; it is about the same mass as the Sun but is older and slightly more evolved